PATH TO FREEDOM

A unique community initiative in the western districts of Arunachal Pradesh seeks to document the Dalai Lama's journey through the eastern Himalaya on his escape from Chinese pursuers in March 1959. Over the course of 14 days, the Tibetan entourage travelled on horseback and foot from the border at Khendzemane to Khelong, before proceeding to the railhead in Tezpur where a famous press conference was held on April 18. 'Project Freedom Trail'—its patron is Arunachal CM Pema Khandu—will mark 13 waypoints where Tibet's spiritual leader stopped on his journey through what was then known as NEFA. The markers will be tall stones, up to 12 feet high and weighing as much as 7 tonnes. Quarried in Khonoma in the Naga Hills, they are inscribed with text describing the journey in both the Bodhi script and English. The freedom trail stones are likely to be inaugurated in November, but the route is already growing in popularity as a heritage-adventure trail on the 447-km stretch from Zemithang to Orang.





Above: The Dalai Lama's 1959 journey

The Hills Are Alive

Tune into these amazing music fests coming up in the musically inclined Northeast



Ziro festival

Ziro Festival

The 10th edition of this iconic festival will see 10,000 revellers being entertained by 47 Indian and international music acts, including mainstream, Indian classical, folk, EDM and other genres. This time, there will be an additional stage, Takvr, meaning 'stars', which will be on from 7 pm to 3 am, apart from the usual Danyi and Pwlo (sun and moon) stages.

Ziro, Arunachal Pradesh | Sept. 28-Oct. 1 | 4-day pass for ₹8,000, per-day costs ₹2,500 | zirofestival.com

India Vision - Mandala Festival

It's the first year for the two-day EDM and folk fusion festival slated to take place in Dirang, Arunachal Pradesh. The vision of Lhakpa Tsering from the local Monpa tribe will bring together folk musicians from across India. Tsering explains how Mandala Top, surrounded by the forests of the Mandala Pass at 10,500 feet, is the perfect location for the fest.

Mandala Top, Dirang, Arunachal Pradesh | Nov. 4-5 | Entry fee ₹1,000 per person per day | www.instagram.com/mandala_indiavisionfestival

Cherry Blossom Festival

What started as a celebration of cherry blossoms in Shillong has since grown into a festival encompassing everything from music to beauty pageants to traditional dances to cosplay. Their early lineup is out: former Boyzone-singer-gone-solo Ronan Keating, London-based DJ Jonas Blue, popular Portuguese Linkin Park tribute band Hybrid Theory, Taiwanese EDM star Kenny Musik and DJ Pink Panda. Local faves like Lou Majaw, hip hop and R&B star Meba Ofilia, and rock band Snow White will also be big draws.

Shillong, Meghalaya | Nov. 17-19 | Three-day pass for ₹3,000 | www.shillongcherryblossom.com

Majuli Music Festival

After amazing performances by When Chai Met Toast, Rain in Sahara, Gauley Bhai and Lucky Ali in previous years, the indie music festival's fourth edition promises 40 fabulous acts across three stages. The sustainable fest is committed to boosting the local economy and fostering rural development and tourism.

Majuli Island, Assam | Nov. 24-26 | ₹1,200 per person per day |majulimusicfestival.com

Hornbill Festival

This pathbreaking cultural and music festival is now in its 23rd edition. The Task Force for Music and Arts (TaFMA), Nagaland, has replaced the contest format with a full-on Hornbill Music Festival this time. Apart from the headlining bands performing in Dimapur, the real Hornbill experience entails getting closer to Naga tribal culture at the main venue.

Naga Heritage Village, Kisama, Kohima, Nagaland | Dec. 1-10 | www.hornbillfestival.com

Priya Pathiyan